The Disappearing Bookshelf

The dangers of letting screentime overpower storytime

Chapter I:
The Foundations of Young Reading

Benefits begin in a child's first months and last a lifetime.

Brain growth

Reading stimulates brain development and builds social and emotional skills.

Language skills

Reading aloud from birth to age 5 improves language development

Lasting gains

Language exposure at 12–24 months is linked to higher language skills and IQ scores through age 14.

Enhanced vocabulary

Children who read regularly in their first five years hear 1.4 million more words.

Confidence & focus

Early literacy builds self-esteem, attention span and communication skills.

Emotional insight

Reading fiction teaches kids to understand other people's feelings and sharpens memory and concentration.

Chapter II:
The Decline in Reading Rates

Fewer children enjoy reading or do it daily, with significant drops in the US and globally

32.7%

of children aged 8 to 18 enjoy reading in their free time, down 36% since 2005 and lowest since 20 years.

18.7%

of children aged 8 to 18 read something daily in their free time, a nearly 20% decrease since 2005.

40%

of fourth graders performed below the NAEP Basic reading benchmark in 2024.

2.5 X

greater declines in reading achievement at high-poverty schools compared with low-poverty schools

Chapter III:
Screens as a Substitute

While reading time is on the decline, screen time increases drastically with age

Fig. 1. Average daily screen time, by age, 2021

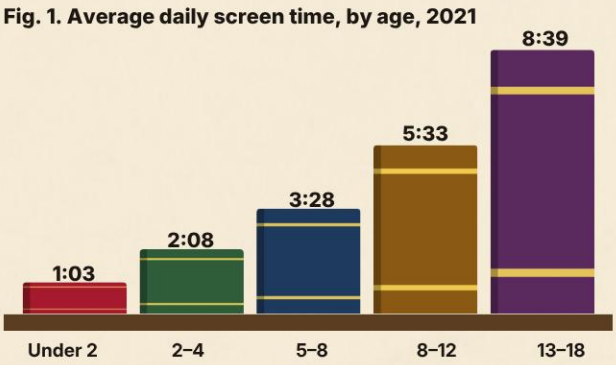
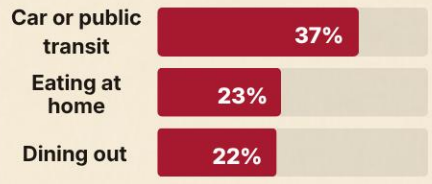


Fig. 2. Media use outside the home, 2024

Parents of children 0 to 8 years olds: child often or sometimes uses a device (bars scaled to 50%)



Ages 0–8 average **32 minutes** of reading a day against **2h 27m** of screens.

Epilogue

- Reading is crucial to development in early years. It is up to role models to encourage its practice.
- Reading rates have dramatically declined in children, which will result in adversity later in life
- Books should not be swapped out for screens. Reading should be encouraged in free time.

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